

powers of the cosmos, which many people believed in when they performed magical rituals to protect their crops or their health. But toward the end of the medieval era, the clergy began to take a harder line against such practices that they labeled witchcraft.

In the Islamic world, and even in Christian Byzantium, magic had a more ambiguous place. Just as in the Western Christian world, folk magic thrived. Muslims believed in fallen angels who had become demons and devilish spirits called *jinn*s, and the use of talismans to protect against them was a part of everyday life—despite their condemnation in the

Quran. The study of magic flourished, too—following the Quran’s instruction to seek knowledge, scholars translated ritual magical texts, while the study of math and natural sciences went hand in hand with advances in alchemy, astrology, and other occult arts.

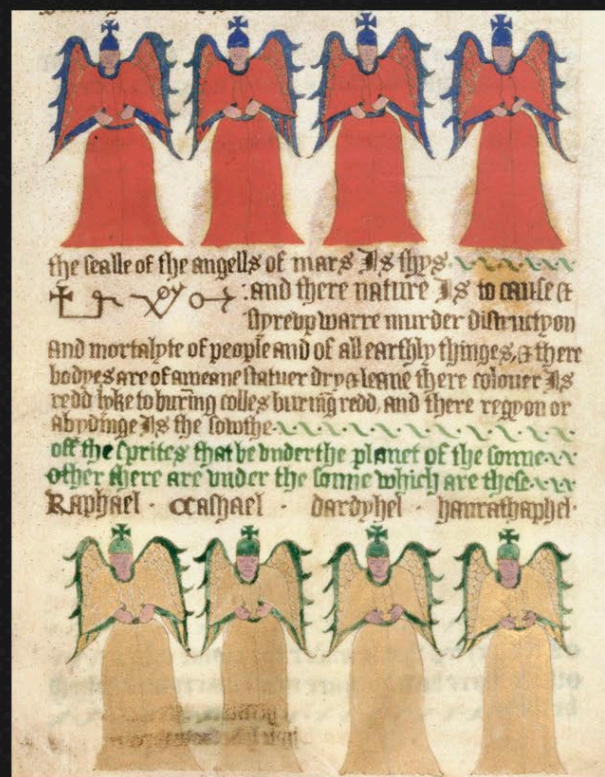
Many key magical works originated in the Islamic world. Latin translations, such as the book known as the *Picatrix*, circulated in Europe and inspired a new interest in magical beliefs and practices among scholars—one reason the modern image of wizards in literature owes more to Islamic scholarship than to native Celtic or Nordic traditions of magic.

“Fashion two images with the first face of Cancer rising, and Venus therein, and the Moon in the first face of Taurus ...”

PICATRIX, BEGINNING OF A LOVE SPELL, 10TH OR 11TH CENTURY



Harvesting mandrake see p.100



Magical handbook on summoning angels see p.109



Trial by fire see p.117